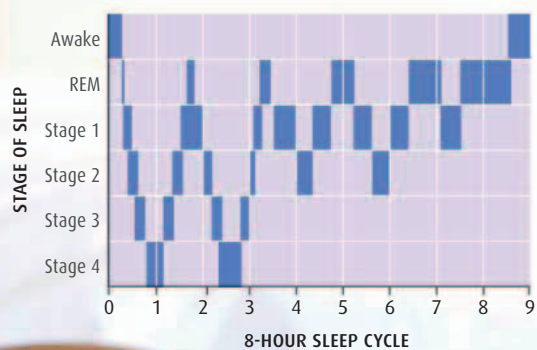




SLEEP CYCLES

When you sleep, your body goes through “sleep cycles,” each taking you through five stages, from light to dreaming to deep and back to light again. Each full cycle lasts around 90 minutes, although the time you spend within each stage varies depending on your overall level of fatigue. For a nap to be effective, you should aim for 50 minutes. If you’re tired, you’ll spend longer in deep, restorative sleep than any of the other stages, but by allowing yourself to come full circle into the light sleep that characterizes the end of a sleep cycle, you’ll wake up feeling refreshed.



Did you know...

During each sleep cycle, we experience a period of REM or “dreaming sleep.” Periods of REM sleep increase for pregnant women from about 25 weeks pregnant onward, spiking at around 33 to 36 weeks. Your dreams aren’t necessarily more vivid, but you are more aware of them.

Sleeping comfortably This will become more difficult as your baby grows. Use pillows and cushions to support your body while you get some rest.

Best practice

Sleep experts call the rituals and practicalities of sleeping our sleep hygiene. Good sleep hygiene is essential to good sleep. So, keep your bedroom dark and cool. Create a bedtime ritual so that your brain learns what the forerunners to sleep are and gets itself ready to switch off. Keep noise and activity levels low in the hour before bedtime—turn off the television, laptops, cell phones, and tablets.

IMPROVE YOUR SLEEP POSITION

Sleeping with sore hip joints, nagging back pain, nasal congestion, heartburn, and a growing baby (not to mention other pregnancy issues) is a challenge in itself. Try these sleeping positions to maximize your chances of a restful night:

- » If you have heartburn or congestion, sleep on your left side. Raise the end of your mattress so that your chest and head are raised slightly.
- » Avoid rolling onto your back, which in the second trimester onward can restrict blood flow to your baby—put a pillow behind your back to stop you from rolling over, if necessary.

Pillow at your back
This stops you from rolling onto your back.



Sleep on your left side This helps to avoid heartburn or congestion.